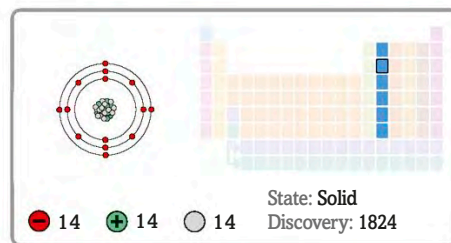


14

Si

# Silicon



## Forms

Amethyst



*This purple form of quartz gets its colour from iron impurities.*

Fulgurite



*This glassy mineral tube is formed when quartz-rich sand is struck by lightning.*

Laboratory sample of pure silicon



*The pure element can shatter easily.*

*Tiny hairs on these leaves have silica tips that break off when you touch them, releasing chemicals that sting.*



Stinging nettle

Sand

*Sand is mostly tiny grains of quartz that have broken away from rocks.*



About 90 per cent of the minerals that make up Earth's rocks contain silicon, a common element in our planet's crust. Nearly all silicon minerals are compounds of silicon and oxygen, known as silicates. The most common silicate is quartz, the mineral form of silicon dioxide, or

silica. It is also the most common substance in sand. **Amethyst** is a type of quartz. Quartz deposits are widely found in rocks such as granite and sandstone. A valuable type of silica is **opal**, which is used as a gemstone. The clays used to make pottery and **ceramics** are also silicates.